Method section checklist

63

AP RESEARCH · ACADEMIC PAPER · SELF-CHECK, THEN PEER CHECK

WRITER'S CODE _____ READER'S CODE _____ DATE _____

What College Board asks of this section: it "explains and provides justification for the chosen method, process, or approach and its alignment with the research question." Two verbs, **explain** and **justify**, and one test, **alignment**.

EXPLAIN: COULD A READER REPEAT IT?

☐	**Who or what.** Who or what was studied, how many, and how they were chosen.
☐	**Instrument.** The survey, interview guide, dataset, or texts are described. The full instrument is in an appendix.
☐	**Steps.** What was done, in order, with dates and how long each part took.
☐	**Analysis.** How the data was analyzed, named plainly: counts, a comparison, coding for themes.

ETHICS: IS IT ON THE PAGE?

☐	**Approval.** Says the study was approved before any data was collected.
☐	**Consent and privacy.** Says how people agreed to take part and how their identities are protected. For public data: says no participants were contacted.

JUSTIFY: WHY THIS, AND NOT SOMETHING ELSE?

☐	**Alignment.** One or two sentences connect the method to the research question in the writer's own words.
☐	**The road not taken.** Names at least one other method and gives a reason it was not used.
☐	**A methods source.** Cites a methods text or a published study for the choice. A blog or infographic does not count.
☐	**Limits.** Names what this method cannot show. Small sample, one school, one year, self-report.

EVIDENCE: CAN IT BE TRACED?

☐	**Every number.** Each number in the section matches the writer's own data file.
☐	**Nothing borrowed.** No number, example, or wording comes from a sample paper or a template.

READER: ONE PLACE I COULD NOT FOLLOW (ASK A QUESTION; DO NOT REWRITE IT)

WRITER: WHAT I WILL CHANGE, IN MY OWN WORDS

Readers ask questions and point to gaps. They do not write, rewrite, or suggest wording. The paper is the writer's own work.